

- **FAB Meeting**
- **Date:** 26 March 2026
- **Location:** Online (Teams)
- **Attendees:** Steve Brain, Jon Flatman, Phil Hall, Martin Wilson, John Bird, Claire Calton
- **Apologies:** Robin Harris, Dominic Wood, Paul Gallagher.

Agenda Items and Discussion

1. Previous Minutes

Steve opened by noting the prompt circulation of previous minutes and set expectations for similar timeliness. No objections were raised.

2. Club Accounts and Financial Position

Jon presented a detailed summary of the club's accounts up to June 2025.

Key points included:

- - Revenue increased by £1.3m (15%), mainly due to a new Sky broadcast deal, improved commercial activity, and a strong cup run.
- - Operating costs fell by £2m, but this was partly due to the previous year being a 13-month period.
- - Wages rose by £1m (like-for-like), driven by first team player costs.
- - Player trading profits were significantly lower than the previous year, resulting in a total loss of £6.5m.
- - The club's bank balance was maintained through £5.3m in owner equity and £4.9m from prior player sales.

Jon highlighted the broader context: average League One losses have risen sharply, with owner funding now averaging £9m per club. He described the situation as unsustainable, warning that the "arms race" in player spending is putting clubs at risk. The club's position is not out of line with the division, but the overall trend is concerning.

Fan representatives acknowledged the gravity of the situation, with Steve and others expressing concern about owner fatigue and the risk of owners walking away.

3. League-wide Financial Crisis and Regulatory Response

Jon explained ongoing efforts at league level to address escalating costs, including discussions around tighter spending rules and a fairer distribution of Premier League money. He noted that a new independent football regulator (IFR) is being established,

which will require clubs to demonstrate financial resilience and fan engagement to obtain a licence.

There was debate about whether clubs can realistically control wage inflation without collective action. Jon was candid about the lack of easy solutions, emphasising the need for unity across clubs and warning that first movers in cost control risk competitive disadvantage.

4. Season Ticket Pricing and Benefits

John Bird outlined proposed season ticket pricing:

- - Average increase of 6% for adults and concessions, equating to £20–£30 per adult and £10–£20 per concession.
- - Matchday prices to rise by £2, with a new “A star” category for high-profile games.
- - Flexi ticket options to be reviewed, with possible removal of the 15-game option due to low uptake.
- - Additional benefits for season ticket holders, including prize draws, mascot packages, hospitality upgrades, and discounts on coach travel.

Fan reps queried the impact of price rises and the effectiveness of flexi tickets. John and Jon acknowledged that sales depend on multiple factors, including team performance, and agreed to continue refining the offer.

5. Communication and Supporter Sentiment

There was discussion of a recent interview with Conor Hourihane, which had not been well received by fans. Jon said he was aware of the negative reaction and would address it in due course.

Steve and others stressed the importance of clear, honest communication, especially around difficult decisions. Jon agreed, noting that upcoming club communications would aim to explain the financial realities and the rationale behind decisions.

6. Protest Incident

The group discussed the recent tennis ball protest. Jon confirmed that those identified had been invited in for meetings and had their tickets suspended pending review. He was firm that such actions are criminal offences and cannot be tolerated, though he recognised the right to protest. Most fan reps felt the protest was embarrassing and counterproductive.

7. Stewarding and Matchday Searches

Concerns were raised about the manner of security searches at recent matches, with some fans finding staff abrupt or accusatory. Jon acknowledged the feedback, explained that increased searches followed the protest incident, and committed to ongoing review with the security provider. He noted that most stewards do a good job but accepted that improvements could be made.

8. Pre-season Events and Anniversaries

Jon and John Bird mentioned plans for pre-season events at Oakwell, including possible World Cup-related activities and concerts, though details were not confirmed. Martin asked about marking the anniversaries of the 2006 and 2016 promotion teams; Jon said the commercial team had plans in hand.

9. Community Trust and Premier League Funding

Phil and Steve reported on a meeting with the Community Trust regarding a funding application for community projects, including outreach to LGBT and ethnic minority groups. The Trust is seeking a 20% increase in Premier League funding, and FAB input was provided.

10. Supporters Trust and FAB Vacancies

There was discussion about the relaunch of the Supporters Trust and the overlap with FAB. Jon suggested joint events and communications to avoid confusion. The group agreed to keep vacancies under review, pending further guidance from the Regulator.

11. Audio Descriptive Commentary

Martin raised the issue of audio descriptive commentary for visually impaired and autistic supporters, particularly at away matches. He is liaising with Cambridge United and offered to share best practice with other clubs.

Actions

- Jon to confirm whether the accounts summary can be published. (New)
- John Bird and Jon to finalise season ticket benefits and communicate details. (Ongoing)
- Club to review stewarding and security feedback with FGH. (Ongoing)
- Jon to prepare and issue a club statement addressing recent issues and financial context. (New)
- Darren (commercial) to progress plans for anniversary events. (Ongoing)
- Phil and Steve to maintain dialogue with Community Trust regarding funding application. (Ongoing)

- Martin to liaise with Cambridge United and share audio commentary best practice. (Ongoing)
- FAB to monitor Supporters Trust relaunch and consider joint events. (Ongoing)

Next meeting Thurs 7th May – 18:00